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Textures in Havana

Memoirs of Material Culture

The history of architecture is a history of spatial feelings.

AUGUST SCHMAROW¹

All my sadness and apprehension fled the moment I caught sight of Havana.

ANAÏS NIN²

If cities are a state of mind, the material projections of our intellectual and emotional energy, they may enable it to thrive, revel, or rest. We have suggested that to live in, or to visit, a city is to partake of a collective space that is intimate, for every place houses its own array of specific historicities, memories, and moods. An urban imaginary is, indeed, a residual archive, colored by *Stimmung*: a mental landscape that accumulates a collection of resonant atmospheres. It is a reservoir of potentialities and projections, which are creative forms of imagination. If each city resonates with a state of mind, one is thus inclined to travel to discover one's own projective geography.

Disposed to think in this way, I eagerly went to Havana to approach aspects of the image of this city that I had encountered in political discourse, literary rendition, music, and visual representation. Havana has the kind of complex web of faded utopian texture, decayed urban fabric, and transformative metropolitan energy that speaks to me. It is a living memory theater, and the fabric of history has a vital material presence here. It is expressed equally in the streets and in the museums, and even "fashioned" in places like the Museum of the Revolution and the Museum of Decorative Arts. In Havana, as one travels from street to museum, a peculiar landscape of textural depth unfolds experientially on the surface of things. Its lively mnemonic chronicle inspired my own, quite personal diary.

A Diary: Impressions on the Surface. Writing in her diary about Havana in 1922, Anaïs Nin noted the particular atmosphere of the city and called it a potential cure to negative states of being. When Havana entered her field of vision, dark thoughts and sorrows vanished,

9.1. Robert Polidori, *Cine Cosmos*, Avenida

19 n° 7011 (between 70 and 72), Playa,

Havana, Cuba, 1997. Digitized 4 × 5 in.

chromogenic color negative film original.

© Robert Polidori. Courtesy of the artist.

and her mood was uncannily boosted. The atmosphere cast a spell on her: “The soft, caressing air and the warm, vibrant touch of its twilight . . . lulled [her] into dreamy indolence.”³ They left her “free from pressure and limitation, soaring above the oppressive phantoms of self-inflicted agony.”⁴ They also left her free to write. In her diary she notes that “with this, the desire to write becomes more intense, the joy of composition becomes ecstasy.”⁵ In offering this female writer release from domination by grief, Havana opened up for her a whole range of subtle, productive sentiments. It quite literally created a novel, diverse territory for her to move in. She wrote about the opening of this new landscape of writing:

The one great privilege attending this state of rest from sorrow is the turn the mind takes once freed from its subjection to one emotion, and how it branches out and embraces the entire situation, and can once more profit from experience and be enriched by it.⁶

If Havana had such a powerful effect on Anaïs Nin, it was because it allowed her to access intimate fabrics of her own imaginary landscape, of which writing was a very important part. For her, Havana created an expanded literary geography, for there she found a way to open up an entire horizon of situations, a vast field of experience, while sensing a place of connection to her own self.

In accessing the layers of her creative imagination, Nin was rendered able to plumb the depths of her personal cultural fabric. The spell of the south returned her to a dormant part of that fabrication. It was a thread that took her back to her family past. Nin’s father, Joaquín Nin, was, in fact, a Cuban musician and composer, and her mother, Rosa Culmell, was a singer of Dutch and French ancestry born in Havana. As she set foot in Havana, Nin’s Cuban roots emerged and, coming to the surface, resonated from within:

You can hardly imagine what it is to see a new city, to hear a new language, to see the faces of an altogether different race and yet to recognize all this as belonging to a part of you. Whatever is Spanish in me has now come to the surface, and in every glance from large dark eyes I read feelings to which I can respond and characters I understand as well as my own.⁷

I too felt strangely at home the moment I set foot in Havana, felt lifted from apprehension and sorrow. I too felt the urge to write in a more intimate, diaristic form, and felt the pleasure in this writing. The spell of this city was definitely upon me. I did not need to ask myself why, for I knew the answer, intrinsically. Such a “superficial” discovery of familiarity with the unfamiliar occurs only when a close psychic landscape is touched upon. In the resilient, energetic, suave harbor town of Havana, I recognized a ruined landscape I knew intimately. In Havana, I came into contact with the Latin part of me that I had left behind in the ruinous Bay of Naples. Walking along the bend of the Malecón, Havana’s own sea promenade, its urban erotic motion transported me to that lively place of the past that is nevertheless still present in me. The spell was happily cast, and the atmosphere took me back, in time and space. I let myself be transported to this other city of ruins.

An Urban Travelogue. Havana impressed me with its intense, and intensely ruinous, urban atmosphere. The layers of history that are deposited here are frozen in the surface of its fantastic architecture. In this city, history is written in stone and melancholically arrested in midair. As the photographs of Havana by Robert Polidori compellingly testify, what was already temporal is often even more precarious in its state of decay and status as remnant.⁸ The interior compositions captured by this architectural photographer render the inner life of the city. Polidori represents Havana in its constant confrontation with the effects of time. Peeling architectural layers present themselves largely unpolished, majestically redolent of a historical patina. They unfold, offering the opportunity to unpack what lies within their texture. This peeling paint—it is as if the skin of the buildings were being flayed, revealing even the interior shape of the architectural armature. In Havana, the urban intestines show. All that is solid rots, and melts in the air.

The surface has depth here. As the paint crumbles, the rust settles, and the mildew spreads, a living fabric reveals itself. This is an arresting fabrication, so lived-in as to become almost an architectural unconscious. Havana does not exhibit the self-congratulatory beauty that Jean-Paul Sartre ascribed to “fake cities . . . that crumble to pieces as one enters them,” but rather shows the textural quality of those less domesticated and sanitized environments that “feed on textile.”⁹ Traversed in time and space by the now-peeling layers of several cultures, the resilient city shows itself off almost archaeologically. A sense of place emerges from its urban texture of diverse ruins, and it is exposed in the layering of surfaces.

This capital city of historically cosmopolitan standards maintains its sense of urbanity despite historical adversity and scarce resources. Made up of multiple ethnicities, this metropolitan society has a diverse identity and pursues relations with many different cultures, in this sense defying even the embargo. Interactions with Latin America and Europe, and with its African heritage, contribute to cultural transits, and to the richly varied cultural landscapes of the city’s important international film festival and art biennial. Thanks to a sustained commitment to education, there is not only a high level of literacy but curiosity about knowledge. It is not rare to sense a particular disposition to human and cultural encounter, an opening up to the very sense of knowledge. In this cosmopolis, one may even encounter a special *savoir*, a way of knowing how to cultivate life.

A lover of cities is bound to yearn for the worldly rhythm conveyed by this urban environment. Havana, in its own synesthetic way, paints a moving image of cultural sounds. This cultural movement is the product of the intersecting flow of music, visual art, architecture, and general style of visual display. The image of this city is clearly associated with its music, and with a layered architectural fabric, a vibrant contemporary art scene, and an urban cinematic rhythm, so fashion is perhaps not what one might expect to find in Havana. Yet, as often happens in cultures that have a passion for urban design and that nurture their living fabric by way of inventive imagings, its texture includes the ways in which the inhabitants present themselves on the street. Despite the lack of means and limited access to luxury



9.2. Robert Polidori, *Señora Luisa Faxas residence*, n° 318 Calle Secunda (at the corner of Avenida 5ta.), Miramar, Havana del Oeste, Cuba, 1997. Digitized 4 × 5 in. chromogenic color negative film original.
© Robert Polidori. Courtesy of the artist.

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goods, fashion is indeed a component of the musical rhythm of Havana. Self-fashioning is part of the urban body's sensuous way of moving. It is a piece of the diffuse, suave, erotic surface of a city whose historic fabric extends well beyond its colonial past.¹⁰

Havana is home to an extraordinary range of inventive modernist architecture, which constitutes a large and stunning portion of its urban landscape. The sensual trend of the city's urban motion is particularly in sync with this Cuban style of modernist dwelling, which twists the canon in favor of more dynamic shapes. It responds to the beaux-arts buildings, which almost dance with eclecticism. It is exuded from the art nouveau and art deco architecture,

as shown off in the rhythm of an ornament, hung as a rounded balcony, or painted on a sign with a swinging graphic design. A staggering number of old movie theaters sport moving architectures, and streamlined bus stops have been designed in equally creative ways, with the city's motion in mind.¹¹ And all is, of course, in tune with the extravagant 1940s American cars that still run, or rather puff, in the streets, adding their own sound to the pulse of the city. A suave metropolis of diverse styles of urban dwelling, Havana lives and dies by design.

An Urban Museographic Design. If visual display is everywhere a presence, this certainly does not exclude the city's museums. Havana is full of them. Besides the well-known array of art museums and art centers, including the National Museum of Fine Arts and the Centro de Arte Contemporáneo Wifredo Lam, which is the organizer of the Havana Bienial, there are many museums devoted to material culture. There appears to be a museum for just about everything imaginable, and even for the implausible, such as Napoleonic artifacts, a collection of which is proudly displayed in a converted mansion. This culture, in which memory is alive and living, appears interested in cultivating aspects of museum culture beyond the paradigmatic art museum. The innumerable exhibitions of objects in Havana's museums function for the city's dwellers and its visitors as a complex display of cultural materials.

How ones lives, and lives by design, is the subject of display in Havana. There is even a museum devoted to perfumes and their bottles, which exhibits eccentric objects designed to contain the essence by which one fashions one's own corporeal fragrance. The perfume museum is located in the Old Town, near pharmacies that have not changed their displays in years, even in half a century. This is evident at the Sarrá pharmacy, frozen in time, as poignantly rendered in a "still" by Robert Polidori. At times we are even catapulted directly into nineteenth-century fashions of display. In Havana's pharmacological culture, we can experience materially the feel of nineteenth-century taxonomy, the particular way of cataloging that pervaded knowledge in that era and was also widely practiced in the museums. For example, in another pharmacy of Habana Vieja, Farmacia Taquechel, extant since 1898, the taxonomic form of knowledge is alive and well, if dusted off now for the appreciative tourists. Here, old jars and vases of mysterious herbal concoctions adorn shelves that also proudly exhibit a skeleton encased in a vitrine. Presented as an anatomical model, the skeleton inhabits a physical landscape made of corporeal remedies. Given the form of its display, this particular pharmacy is a hybrid material remnant. It is, indeed, a Cuban version of a nineteenth-century European anatomical museum.

Designing Interiors: A Cuban Countess's Drawing Room. Marked as it is, by choice as well as by dire necessity, with design relics, the city of Havana even has a museum entirely devoted to the fashion of living. In the fashionable section of Vedado stands the Museo de Artes Decorativas, a shrine to the countess who furnished and inhabited the

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two-story palace it occupies, which used to be her home. The building is not unlike many others in some sections of this neighborhood. Some of these grand private domestic architectures have been made public and are used as schools, cultural venues, gathering places for various organizations or unions, and post offices, if not museums. For example, a house designed in 1926 in a rare French-style art deco is now la Casa de la Amistad, run by ICAP, the Cuban Institute for Friendship among the Peoples. Many of these former mansions retain their domestic use. They have been socialized and, in some cases, made into multiple-family dwellings. Hard to maintain and restore and often badly converted into apartments, these once majestic homes frequently show some signs of disrepair, if not decomposition. The patina of history that emerges from the rot and the peeling layers of paint is here a daily affair to contend with. The challenge of everyday life in this city involves managing advanced states of deterioration, and trying to adapt modern life to history.

The villa of María Luisa Gómez Mena, Condesa de Revilla de Camargo, is a museum that reveals the appearance and function of these mansions before they became socialized. The woman who lived in this particular mansion was the sister of José Gómez Mena, known for having built the first shopping arcade in Cuba, in 1910. Her house, constructed between 1924 and 1927 and remodeled in the 1930s, was built in a fanciful, eclectic style developed in the years of economic boom known as *vacas gordas* (fat cows). Traversing the various locales of this French-inflected, neoclassical architecture, crossing rooms decorated with Carrara marble and ascending the grand staircase, one enters the fantasy space of the Cuban countess. This was a retro European fantasy. The countess, a fervent collector, was obsessed with French and Italian furniture and paintings and textiles of the eighteenth and nineteenth century, with which she decorated every room. Her furniture even includes pieces that were formerly housed in Versailles, and a *secrétaire* that belonged to Marie Antoinette. Objects from the past made their way into her rose marble bathroom, designed in art deco style and adorned with Bohemian crystal, French opaline, and boudoir pieces of silver. And, as if she were actually inhabiting those epochs, she collected chinoiserie, with which she adorned an Orientalized salon. A tireless socialite, the countess staged her dining room with a *mise-en-scène* that remade the atmosphere of Regency-style dining. To complete the picture of such recreations, she had an elaborate two-part picturesque garden that functioned according to a classic script. One side of the garden was devoted to nocturnal feasts and gatherings, the other to more intimate and contemplative activities. If one side was a memory theater of sensual pleasures, the other was an exterior designed to put the garden dweller in touch with inner space, projecting an inner world onto the outer geography.

María Luisa incorporated other such “interior” designs into the house. Like every lady of the previous century, she had a drawing room, a product of the eighteenth-century penchant for private architectures. Although created in the 1700s, it remained popular throughout the Victorian age in Europe.¹² The drawing room was a specifically female construction, a feminine space for “withdrawing,” from which it took its English name. This inner space was used for cultivating a woman’s precious moments of privacy and imagination, her time of



dwelling in self-reflection. In its French version, such a room was called *boudoir*, the name derived from the verb *bouder*. As the etymology indicates, this was a place for brooding. Both English and French semiotics reinforce this, suggesting an interior landscape “designed” to accommodate this mental state. The eighteenth-century response to brooding was not, as is the case today, to prescribe a medicine to repress its supposed negativity or correct an alleged chemical imbalance. Rather, this particular sentiment was allowed to exist in the social realm and to be cultivated, was given an architecture, both literally and metaphorically, was afforded time to breathe.

The (with)drawing room, this space intended to make room for an inward state of mind, not only functioned to landscape an affect. It was also designed to house the motion of an emotion. Indeed, the drawing room designed the complex stages in the cultivation of interiority, subjectivity, and intersubjectivity. It mapped a withdrawal inside the self that also contained an opening to the outside, as well as an erotic aperture. The drawing room staged

9.3. Museo de Artes Decorativas, Vedado, Havana. The dining room of María Luisa Gómez Mena, Condesa de Revilla de Camargo. Photo: Giuliana Bruno.

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in the Cuban Museum of Decorative Arts clearly speaks of this architecture as hosting an emotional movement, and an erotically charged design. The particular location in the house of this lady's room gives clear indication of its function. The Cuban countess's own space of retreat was located, *comme il faut*, next to her bedchamber. A door allowed her to pass undisturbed into this solitary space of contemplation, which, at times, as in the general tradition of its use, became the site of confidential conversations, close dialogue, and intimate encounters.

In her boudoir, a lady could indulge in a whole spectrum of moods and travel a landscape of affects that ranged from the morbid to the erotic. She could let herself be moody, remain engrossed in slight malaise, or become possessed by melancholic affects. She could lie rapt in sweet contemplation, rumination, or musing. She could immerse herself in meditative states and slip from disposition to attitude, from absorption to introspection. She could move from such closeness to the self to intimacy with others, and easily segue from intimacy to seduction. The boudoir was thus, fully, a transformative space that made room for interiority to develop outward. This room where one could remain still was actually a traveling room. It hosted journeys of imaginative substance.

All the objects of design necessary for liminal transits to be induced, for the motion of an emotion to occur, for mood to come into place, and for mental atmosphere to be created were there. Surfaces were crafted to this end. The wall of the Cuban countess's drawing room opened up to reveal a painting by François Boucher, a picture she could revel in. Gazing away from the painting, she could rest her glance upon a collection of decorated ladies' fans. Sofas ensured comfort for her body and those of any visitors. But the sofa was not the only character in the withdrawing picture. At center stage was the woman's writing desk. The secretary contained all the accoutrements necessary for staying intent in literary thought and private speculation, whether drafting personal letters, composing secret missives, or writing solitary diary entries.

Another leisurely corner of the drawing room was fashioned by positioning a knitting kit in the shape of a globe there. Next to the window, the lady's collection of fashion prints was featured. These images of style, which circulated widely in women's magazines, were also used to decorate the walls of the home. Fashion was a popular item and an important fad in interior design. Hanging fashion prints was yet another commonplace of a European lady's way of dwelling. The prints chosen by the Cuban countess represented the time and place in which she fashioned herself to be living, staged as her own. They were an image of European making she bought into and appropriated. By way of fashion images and domestic design, the Cuban countess fashioned a way to secure her own place of power in the world. In many ways attuned to feminine arts of subjective makeup, the countess designed herself carefully in the surface design of her own "drawing" room.

The countess's drawing room was a set, a fictive place of the imagination. Like a film set, this room could host a narrative dynamic. In its surroundings, a set of possibilities could take place in forms of cultural mediation and transmission. Design provided a frame with which to recreate a cultural site, offering material access to the history and stories the countess could

project herself into. It now testifies to the fact that the story she desired for herself originated in part from the retroactive fantasy of a privileged European way of life. The drawing room narrates for us the intricate levels of mental fabrication of a Cuban countess's identity and power. It shows, in the texture of its design, the various games of seduction exerted by cultural mimicry. In fact, in this room, as in cinema, it is the very fabric of design that fabricates the inner folds of history and, at the same time, reveals the making of a personal narrative in the space of history. Design materially makes this making of the self readable on the surface. It "screens" for us the history of private space. It also makes such private space travel in time to reach our own spectatorial fantasy of what it might have been like to be there at the time. That is, the fashionable room holds a form of projection. It makes us live a movie. After all, cinema is also both a theater of history and a maker of private space. It is itself a way of traveling in a room of projections, captured and held on the narrative surface of things.

The Fabric of History: The Museum of the Cuban Revolution. Visiting the various museographic displays across the city of Havana, one is able to traverse layers of the complex history of this city in material ways. As the Maqueta, a colossal twenty-two-meter-wide scale model of Havana, shows, history is panoramically written in architectural space here, more clearly than in many other cities in the world. The Maqueta embodies the actual map of this expansive architectural journey. Traveling across the distinct architectural styles that correspond to various epochs and ethnic conjunctions, one can visit different museographic exhibitions of Havana's history, which put us in touch with it materially. Going from Vedado, home of the Museo de Artes Decorativas, to Centro Habana, home of the Museo de la Revolución, is one fascinating journey, allowing us to travel from the interior space of a countess to the design of a revolution. What is particularly interesting about this journey is that both these historicities, though on opposite ends of the social spectrum, are memorialized in the same way; that is, they are documented in the same "fashion." History is told by way of design in Havana. Here, a historical occurrence becomes visible by becoming palpable as a matter of fashion and interior design, and through the materiality of objects.

The Museum of the Revolution is all about attire, photography, interior design, objects, maps, means of transport, and wax models. The curatorial combination is compelling. In advance of contemporary curatorial trends, this Cuban museum of history recognized the importance of design and fashion, among other aspects of material culture. It treats them as both aesthetic and social artifacts, playing with their exhibitionary strengths. Before it became popular, and controversial, to display fashion in museums, the Museum of the Revolution in Havana set an interesting standard of design installation. Here one can sense the function of material space and objects in the making of subjects of history.

The museum is located in a grand building, the former presidential palace, whose architecture is appropriated by the overlay of different imagings. A socialist fresco bearing the texture of fin-de-siècle popular naturalism sets the tone for our entry into the world

9.4. Museo de la Revolución,
Centro Habana, Havana. Skirt
and doll used by women to carry
explosives. Photo: Giuliana Bruno.



of the revolution, which culminates in a dioramic installation with a life-size wax model reproducing the body of Che Guevara. The panoramic fresco and the diorama with the wax model remind us that, as a historical event, the notion of a Marxist revolution originated in the age of mechanical reproduction. Its history is inseparable from that of modernity and its forms of visual display. In this respect, the idea of revolution is also bound up with modernity's new art forms: photography and celluloid. It makes sense, therefore, that a site devoted to documenting the Cuban Revolution, a late but most lasting phenomenon, would use photography to tell its story. The curatorial gesture acknowledges a historical conjunction and uses a modern language to construct a material historicity.

Rows of vitrines exhibit pictures of the revolution. Exposed in a sequence, and read progressively, the encased pictures "frame" the movement of a microhistory. The photographic face of the revolution is made not only from its grand heroes but, mostly, from the secondary figures and even the average people who participated in it. One by one, minor, even unknown members of the various stages of the revolutionary process are given a face. The people are photographically embodied. Here is a student, a worker, a teacher. Over there, some poor fellow who nonetheless generously gave money to the revolution. Next to the photo, an inscription informs us, in all seriousness, that he wanted to give even more money but was advised to hang on to it, for no one should deprive himself of all resources—you never know what might happen. All the inscriptions, like this one, relate some kind of commonplace or simply a common story. They are lengthy narratives that speak of everyday occurrences and convey small, ordinary details. We thus begin to get the picture.

This museum allows us to enter a corner of the revolutionary space, for it gives us access to the people involved, the places they inhabited and traversed, the things they used. Objects of material culture join in the creation of this microhistory. Along with photographs, the vitrines exhibit personal objects, minor artifacts, belongings, and all kinds of traces of the everyday life of those involved in the revolt. In this display, clothes figure large and get center stage. One after the other, as in a fashion show, we are shown the stylish shirts worn by the young men, the neat skirts donned by the women. Here is the well-made, ornate shirt that a student leader wore during a manifestation of protest. Over there, another good-looking shirt worn during the struggle against Batista. Even the tie someone wore during an attack on one of his prisons. In this other room hangs a casual coat worn at the ceremony for the 1976 constitution. Dapper, smartly dressed, good-looking young men. It wasn't just El Che who was a revolutionary sex symbol. We get the picture.

As far as this museum is concerned, the Cuban Revolution was "fashioned." It was, quite literally, fabricated and tailored. In case there is any doubt, here comes the sewing machine. A good old-fashioned one is exhibited, complete with ornate iron legs and foot pedal. We are informed that this machine, a regular domestic item here elevated to museum status, belonged to a revolutionary woman's mother. It was used to make revolutionary uniforms, especially fatigues to be donned by oversize men. That, of course, included Fidel Castro. Along with him, grandma's sewing machine has entered history.

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9.5. Museo de la Revolución,
Centro Habana, Havana. Shirt
worn by a revolutionary.
Photo: Giuliana Bruno.

So have typewriters and glasses, dolls and spoons, cups and skirts, pans and weights. All make their sparse, minimalist appearance in the museum installation. The room dedicated to the revolutionary women is particularly interesting in this respect. A huge picture of two women is disposed next to a vitrine in which hangs a fashionable, nicely textured skirt. Below the skirt there is a metal cup, and next to this a spoon and a fork. To get the picture, we have to move forward. As in the filmic situation, meaning in the museum is carried by object-images displayed in a sequence. As we proceed, two photographs show us the women again, this time in jail, and literally behind bars. We understand that the skirt belonged to one of them. It is the attire that Haydée Santamaría was wearing when imprisoned for participating in the events of July 26, 1953. The sad-looking, lonely metal cup is the utensil she had at her disposal in the penitentiary. This museum display is not far removed from the look of an art installation. This could be *arte povera* with a political mission.

In fact, the revolution is “installed” here, and in mixed media. Assemblages of disparate objects and montages of mundane, poor materials are charged with political meaning. Sparse spatial representations replete with metonymic artifacts create storytelling environments. In one instance, we find a vitrine displaying a simple pot set in front of a strange object—two pieces of stone connected by a metal bar. The scene is as minimal as a conceptual art piece. The construction, we discover, is a makeshift weight the revolutionary men used in order to stay fit, while the pot reminds us of the body’s corporeal needs.

As in the art installations that populate the trendy galleries and contemporary art museums of today’s major cities, the vitrines of Havana’s Museum of the Revolution display composite pictures of narrative design objects. In one room, an old-fashioned doll is exhibited. She exudes a patina of nostalgia with her dressed-up air, waxen skin, and pink ball dress, and especially with the way she dangles from the wall. Next to the doll is a picture. It shows the doll decapitated. Over both these images an elaborate piece of clothing is suspended, a fluffy black organza underskirt opened up to show its insides. Name the artist. . . . No, it is not Rosemarie Trockel, though it feels like one of her early installations. This is another form of material history made material. The display is a testimony to how Cuban women used to carry explosives, right here, inside the bodies of their dolls, or how they hid guns, right there, inside their underskirts. Thus fabricated, the fabric of this installation is a material reenactment of an event.

The event, held thus in the design of material culture, appears both present and suspended. As with the art installations of Charles LeDray, the fabric of clothes here offers a miniature yet magnified representation of the borders between life and death. As in the vitrines of LeDray’s *My Hands, My Father’s Hands* (1991), here too the clothes are exhibited like specimens, the diaphanous fabric of ripped shirts returning to us an act of violence. In the Museum of the Revolution, the clothes carry with them, in traces visible on the surface, a sense of trauma and the force of its history. Some of the outfits are damaged, torn, lacerated. Bullet holes are visible on some of the shirts. Bloodshed is documented as stains on the fabric. A bloodstain seeps through next to what may be a food stain. Violence or death,



9.6. Charles LeDray, *Untitled*, 1995.
 Fabric, thread, plastic, paint, wood,
 wire, gold plated brass buttons, 20 1/4 ×
 12 3/4 × 4 in. Private collection. Courtesy
 of Sperone Westwater, New York.

the shirt says, was not abnormal in the fabrication of the revolution. We get to experience this now by way of the fabric of clothes and the surface of things.

The Museum of the Revolution is disquieting for the way in which it creates this experiential affect with concrete, minimal means. It puts us in close touch with the experience of a traumatic historicity by picturing and documenting physical aspects of the life of the dead and presenting us with their material belongings. This minimal yet cumulative curatorial strategy is reminiscent of that used, for example, at the Holocaust Museum in Washington, DC, to screen its own traumatic moment of history. In this museum, shoes and pictures are related on an indexical level, and used in interchangeable ways. Photos and clothes are employed interchangeably in Havana, too, as a material museographic practice that is a tangible way of representing trauma. Exhibiting the material history that design is able to convey not only makes history material but also exposes a concrete cultural design. The weave of this museographic design fabricates a modern historicity, for it exhibits an important aspect of modern culture. Here we can see how much visual display is tied to trauma, inasmuch as this intersection is a modern form of representation. The design of the exhibition in Havana ultimately reminds us that photography and material consumption are, historically, intrinsic parts of the traumatic history of modernity.

In this haptic way, through the fabric of a representational design, the visitor is asked to remember the revolution and keep it alive, for the endurance of objects makes it live. For this reason, the Museum of the Revolution is full of things. It is an endless display of reading glasses, typewriters, letters, maps, pictures, shoes, favorite shirts or worn-out skirts, and many other daily vestiges that metonymically refer to the live body of a departed person. These remnants of everyday lives acknowledge those who fell in pursuit of the revolutionary cause in the same way that a deceased person's clothes and possessions corporeally speak of them, connect us back to them. In this sense, this is less a museum and more of an archive. As in a personal archive, the traces people have left behind are the matter that allows those who remain to access their lives and process their deaths. A person who has lost a dear friend or family member may choose to keep, and cherish, what was most closely attached to their body. Clothes are such a material archive. When people depart, their shirts still smell of them, for a long time after.

In the vitrines of Havana's Museum of the Revolution, as in archival evocations of the Holocaust by the artist Christian Boltanski, there is a loneliness to clothes. The body that inhabited them has departed, and they are left hanging, testimony not only to the passing of life but to the passing of time. Cloth that was lived in, animated by life, is now faded and fading, a material memory of things past. The withered fabric speaks of a "wearing" that is also a "wearing out." Here, the memory inscribed in the garments embodies the actual texture of a violent historic event, the revolutionary moment in Cuban history represented as rupture by way of ripped clothes. The tearing of cloth reveals the tearing of the social fabric. In this sense, the history of revolt is not too simply constructed in a celebratory fashion. In the threads of the torn shirts belonging to the casualties of that rupture, one feels the thread of pain, and with the fading fabric comes a painful sense of endurance.

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The curatorial vision of the museum is attuned to strategies that enable viewers to construct, and socialize, an emotional landscape that includes the complicated texture of pain. Standing before its vitrines, we are asked to share in this landscape just as we do when confronted with the kind of archive fashioned by the Colombian installation artist Doris Salcedo.¹³ In her work, too, the fabric of cloth speaks of the fabric of a traumatic history. In her spatial artworks evoking the difficult history of her country, objects of furniture accompany articles of clothing as documents of a material history, much as they do in the Havana museum. Past is made into present by the combined presence of common clothes and domestic objects. The folds of the garments unfold a personal story at a historic time. The fabrication of the installations impel the museumgoer to become engaged, with all of her senses, in their affective, textural space. It is not enough to look at a sculpture by Salcedo, for she demands a haptic relation with her tactile work. In covering a table with a layer of silky cloth, she asks for the palms of our hands to touch it in order to read the work. In *Unland*, subtitled *the orphan's tunic* (1997), her table is dressed as if with skin. Other objects of furniture are similarly fashioned. When in *Untitled* (1995) she presents an armoire filled with clothes, now laden with cement, the fabric of the buried cloth painfully seeps out of the cement to tell a story. Salcedo here asks that we enter into an emotional fabric, for the narrative text emerges from the hardened surface of that material texture of the cloth. We are drawn into the secret drawers of the violent history that took place in the house she portrays. In this woman artist's work we materially access, on the surface, a history that came to perturb an intimate geography.

This is a matter of surface, and of what can show on the surface of things, including the forms of contact and projection that create *Einfühlung*, that "feeling into" which is empathy. If cloth has touched the body, and is texture to be touched, exposing this fabric, as Salcedo does, demands an affective contact that generates empathy. It is this form of contact that we may also encounter in the display of clothes at Havana's Museum of the Revolution. The archival design that is exposed here has a similar emotional fabric when it manages to become an intimate way of telling a history, when it effectively returns to us the fabric of an intimate yet public space. As it designs the domestic text of history, the Museum of the Revolution can make a show of collective memory, which is not only alive but lived in on the minimal surface of things.

In the Cuban Museum of the Revolution, even the ideological text is materially installed, its representation tailored to objects, and displayed spatially, in an almost conceptual way. A simple table stands in a room. It is immaculately painted a lucid, pure institutional white. On its surface lie three faded pieces of paper, torn from well-worked notebooks. Above the table, a large rectangular blackboard towers. The slab of slate is absolutely black, with white trim around it. It is vacant, empty, utterly barren. Over the blank, black surface hovers a small inscription: "Academia ideológica." This is a reenactment of the Cuban Ideological Academy. It is quite the postminimalist installation.

Making "room" for the revolution appears to be on the agenda of this museum, and the point is driven home, so to speak, by a most telling domestic museum installation. In one room



of the Museum of the Revolution, an architectural model of a house is exhibited. The large-scale model represents one of the many modernist dwellings built in Havana. To understand exactly what this is doing here, we must again recall that the city was largely developed into a modern metropolis in the period from the 1920s through the 1950s, and features an impressive, vast expanse of extremely creative modernist and moderne architecture.¹⁴ The local vernacular of modernism took shape in intersection with the European-American modern architectural movement, including, among other connections, the presence of Richard Neutra, who himself built a remarkable home in Havana.¹⁵ In the 1960s, revolutionary modern forms appeared

9.7. Doris Salcedo, *Unland: the orphan's tunic*, 1997. Wood, cloth, and hair.

Photo: David Heald. Courtesy of Alexander and Bonin, New York.

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in residential dwelling as well as public works. A stunning example, for the way in which it pushes Catalan vaults into postrevolutionary modernism, is the visionary architecture of the Escuelas Nacionales de Arte, a project comprising five schools of art, designed by Ricardo Porro, Vittorio Garatti, and Roberto Gottardi between 1961 and 1965.¹⁶

Against this background, it appears suitable that a classic, albeit uninspired, example of this modernist revolutionary architecture would be featured in the Museum of the Revolution. This is a small-scale, more domestic version of the dwelling chosen by Castro, who, after taking power, took up residence atop the Hilton hotel. Now called the Habana Libre, it is an emblematic modernist skyscraper, designed in 1958, that towers over the neighborhood of El Vedado.¹⁷ The hotel still features in its lobby evidence of the passage of Fidel, who turned a place of transit into home—thus choosing a mobile concept of home as a revolutionary symbol. To confirm that this story of modernist travel-dwelling is part of the history of the revolution, the museum proudly exhibits a model of the modernist house where brother and sister Abel and Haydée Santamaría lived, also in the Vedado section of Havana. The legend, near the model, tells us that the actions of July 26, 1953, were planned there.

Peeking down from above, we can peer into this home and imagine what it must have been like to live there. We can enter the place, like a fly on the wall, or a film spectator, and observe the life that went on in the apartment. In fact, the model of the home is fully furnished, and reproduces for us the actual living conditions of its revolutionary dwellers. The boxy structure is rationally subdivided. The apartment is comfortable and well equipped, supplied with all the modern conveniences, including nice kitchen and bathroom appliances. We notice, however, that the furniture does not fit the aesthetic of the apartment. There are no objects of modern design here. A rather pedestrian set of wooden furniture is scattered around. In the bedroom an old-fashioned, oversize armoire sits in front of a window, blocking the light. It appears as if the pair inherited this furniture from their family and did the best they could to fit it into their modernist dwelling. In the living room, a sofa, a desk, and a dining room table are disposed in the model home, arranged just as they were in real life.

As if one were watching a movie of the revolutionary process, a spatial visualization of the event emerges. With this spatialization on the surface of the walls comes a narrative. Looking at this fictional set of revolution making, one can imagine the smoky evenings of heated discussions that took place around the table. One can empathize with the participants in the actions that eventually led to the revolutionary moment. In fact, one of the effects of exhibiting the model of this home is that the revolution itself becomes inhabitable. It becomes, in ways that are both literal and metaphorical, livable. As a personal architecture and a private design construct the contours of the revolution, the grand historic fact becomes a shared social narrative. In a tangible way, this becomes a manageable process. In the end, the act of representing a domestic architecture domesticates even the violent revolutionary process.

Recognizing a curatorial strategy not unlike that used in the Museum of Decorative Arts, in the Museum of the Revolution we encounter a dynamic interplay of private and public in the narrativization of history on the surface of things. Both museums make space



for the private dimensions of historic times and, ultimately, conceive of history as the historicity of private space. For the Museum of the Revolution, this dimension of privacy is an important way of documenting the country's most prominent public event. It becomes a way of socializing its archive, intimately.

It is by way of interior design that we access the intimate making of history as it is fashioned on the surface of objects of material culture. Objects display a transmittable narrative on their surface. Mediated in this surface space are matters of cultural transits. The personal architecture that is expressed in design and apparel is not only a trace of the self but also a projection of intersubjective, social, and public life. In Havana, this public intimacy is palpable, as displayed in the layers of cultural memory and folds of textuality that are inscribed in the atmosphere of the city. The depth of surface is an integral part of its imaginative urban design, and it also appears displayed on the walls of its museums.

No wonder I felt at home there.

9.8. Museo de la Revolución, Centro Habana, Havana. Model of the apartment of Abel and Haydée Santamaría, located at 25 y O, Vedado, Havana. Photo: Andrew Fierberg.

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